distribution of 7.4 million coffee plants in 2015. Plans for 2016 call for the distribution of another 8.5 million coffee plants for the repopulation of 15 percent of coffee-producing areas across the country by the time the current administration leaves office. Rust monitoring data as of October 2015 puts the nationwide incidence rate at eight percent. However, this figure has risen since October with the high levels of rainfall in the past three months, although the exact impact has yet to be determined.

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Nicaragua: November 14th marked the official beginning of the 2015/2016 coffee harvest in Nicaragua. Estimates by the National Coffee Council (CONACAFE) put nationwide production approximately nine percent above the figure for last season, with production growing from 2.3 million *quintals* to 2.5 million *quintals*.

Projected regional outlook through March 2016

Subsistence farmers in the Dry Corridor of Central America were severely affected by losses of *Primera* crops. Most of these farmers grow maize, which they then consume over a period of several months. They will have no maize stocks for the first eight months of 2016 to help meet household food needs, until the next harvest begins in August 2016. Thus, affected households will depend on income from the sale of assets, wage labor, or harvests of *Postrera* and/or *Apante* crops. Rainfall anomalies during the 2015 rainy season (including both rainfall deficits and excessive rains) also affected other agricultural activities (involving crops such as peanuts, sugar cane, bananas, citrus fruits, and cattle), impacting employment across the region. At the same time, the coffee sector is recovering to varying degrees in each country, which will contribute to the generation of employment opportunities.

Contrary to seasonal forecasts, good distribution of rainfall beginning in the second half of September facilitated the development of *Postrera* crops, consisting primarily of beans throughout the region. *Primera* season losses in all three countries triggered the implementation of food assistance programs, which have temporarily mitigated food security outcomes.

Based on the most likely scenario, households of small-scale staple producers and coffee growers concentrated mainly in the Dry Corridor, as